



► Rallying cry

Women and men marched together to the Bastille on July 14, 1789. The fall of the prison signified the toppling of the king's authority and the beginning of the French Revolution.

18-year-old Emily Geiger was captured by British forces in 1781 while taking a message to General Greene on the front lines. No evidence was found among her belongings—she had memorized the message and eaten the paper—so Geiger was released.

In both the French and American revolutions, some women were so determined to join the war effort that they disguised themselves as men. Anna Maria Lane of Virginia dressed as a man and fought for the rebels alongside her husband in the Continental Army. When she was wounded at the Battle of Germantown, Lane refused treatment for her injury. This was understandable, since most of the women caught serving as men were discovered while receiving medical treatment. Like their American counterparts, women who fought in the French Revolutionary Wars also went to great pains to hide their bodies from scrutiny, binding their breasts and cutting their hair in order to enlist as men.

Enlightened women

The French revolution began in 1789 and was followed by years of warfare as the rest of Europe fought to contain its antimonarchist spirit. Women were involved from the very beginning. In July 1789, women joined men in storming the Bastille (a Parisian fortress that held political prisoners) and in October,



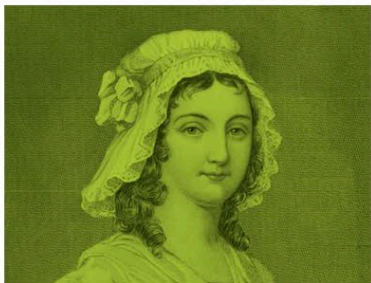
marched to the royal palace of Versailles (see pp. 134–135). Educated in the philosophy of the Enlightenment, female intellectuals wrote bold treatises advocating women's rights, or joined political clubs such as the

Society of Republican and Revolutionary Women. Women in both France and the US wrote pamphlets and novels about the role of women in a republic.

This political opposition was as dangerous for women as it was for men, if not more so. In 1793, the National Convention in France banned women's political associations. Olympe de Gouges, writing under the name "Polyme," criticized

Robespierre and his Jacobins (the extremist faction in power) and was executed during the Terror of 1793–1794, in which critics of the regime—particularly women—were

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demands for
equal rights were
made by radical
Hungarian
women in 1848



BIOGRAPHY CHARLOTTE CORDAY

Marie-Anne Charlotte Corday d'Armont was born in 1768 into a poor but noble family in Caen, France. She later became involved with the moderate Girondists. In 1793, horrified by the brutality of the Jacobin Terror, Corday traveled to Paris. There, she tricked her way into a meeting with Jacobin leader Jean-Paul Marat by promising to betray the names of fellow Caen Girondists, and stabbed him in his bathtub. Corday was executed by guillotine for the murder that same year.